

YOU'LL SEE THAT LIFE ISN'T LIKE FAIRY TALES

PAN'S LABYRINTH / 2006

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Fantasy, war

DIRECTOR

Guillermo del Toro

WRITER

Guillermo del Toro

STARS

Ivana Baquero, Sergi López, Maribel Verdú

BEFORE

1984 *The Company of Wolves* is an early example of the "dark fairy tale" movie genre.

2001 *The Devil's Backbone*, described by del Toro as the "brother movie" to *Pan's Labyrinth*, follows a group of boys in a haunted orphanage.

AFTER

2013 Blockbuster *Pacific Rim* is del Toro's take on Japanese *kaiju* (monster) movies.

Fairy tales abound with the sinister and the macabre. Good invariably conquers evil, but the battle is hard fought and evil is not without power. It seems fitting, then, that one of the directors who has best captured the essence of the fairy tale on movie is one who made his name in horror. Mexican director Guillermo del Toro had honed his talent for

unsettling audiences for more than a decade before making *Pan's Labyrinth*. In the manner of the best fairy stories, he succeeds in finding a way both to challenge innocence and to celebrate it.

Fantasy vs reality

Pan's Labyrinth consists of two narratives unfolding at the same time. One tells the story of Vidal, a captain in General Franco's Nationalist army who has been sent to the mountains to round up the remnants of the defeated Republicans in the aftermath of the Spanish Civil War.

The other is the story of his stepdaughter, Ofelia. She is a young girl who is very much lost in the world and who, either through her imagination or by magic (the movie cleverly leaves this question open), escapes to a fantasy realm where she assumes the spirit of a long-dead fairy princess.

A faun sets her three tasks to complete before she can be permitted to take her rightful place in the magical kingdom. »



In this magical and immensely moving film, the two sides of the film come together to constitute an allegory about the soul and the national identity of Spain.

Philip French
The Observer

